

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NORTH MACEDONIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the rivers, forests, and wild places of North Macedonia, and one long campaign proved that even when a government is determined to build, a project can be stopped by cutting off the money at its source. In the west of the country lies **Mavrovo**, the oldest and largest national park in North Macedonia, and one of the last homes of the critically endangered **Balkan lynx**. When the government planned two large hydropower dams inside the park — **Boškov Most** and **Lukovo Pole** — the projects depended on loans from two international development banks, the **World Bank** and the **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development**. A small Macedonian organisation and its allies saw the weakness in that dependence and struck at it. They did not only protest; they held the banks to their own written environmental rules, filing complaints to the banks' own accountability mechanisms and proving the banks had broken their own biodiversity policies. They brought in an international wildlife treaty, whose committee called for the construction to stop. They rallied scientists, a court, and the public around the lynx and the park. And it worked: in 2015 the World Bank withdrew its funding, in 2017 the EBRD cancelled its loan, and without the international money the dams could not be built. A national park, and a nearly-extinct wild cat, were saved by a campaign that followed the money. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a fight is won. The park was no ordinary place — the oldest and largest in the country, already burdened by two dams from the 1950s, and one of the very last refuges of a wild cat so rare that only a few dozen survive. The campaign that saved it was led by a small research and information organisation in the capital, working with international finance-watchdog and conservation networks that knew the development banks' rules from the inside. Their central insight was that the dams could not be built without the international loans, and that those loans came bound by the banks' own environmental policies — so they lodged a formal complaint, and an independent review found that one of the banks had indeed broken its own rules by failing to assess the harm to the park's wildlife. A European wildlife treaty then called for the construction to stop; scientists and the public rallied to the lynx; and, one after another, the banks pulled out.

The North Macedonia story teaches two things about defending land here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly from the outset. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected place, the documentation, the coalition, the campaign, and the pressure — pressed together. The second is distinctly Macedonian, and it was forged in the fight for Mavrovo. **When a destructive project depends on international financing, the surest way to stop it may be to cut off that money — by holding the development banks to their own environmental safeguard policies, invoking international treaties, and drawing global attention to what would be lost.** That power — following the money to the international financiers, using the banks' own rules against them, and wielding international treaties and attention — is North Macedonia's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Mavrovo campaign work as a model, and what a later campaign can copy, was its refusal to fight only where the project seemed strongest — in a government office determined to build — and its choice to strike instead where it was weakest, at the distant source of its money. A determined government can override local protest; it cannot conjure the hundred million and more that two great dams require, and when that money is bound by rules the project breaks, and watched by institutions beyond the government's reach, the project's greatest strength becomes its fatal vulnerability. Follow the money, find the rules it carries, and force the financiers to honour them: that is the template.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The Mavrovo win **cut off the financing**, but for a time the government did not formally cancel the projects, and the park still faced other, smaller hydropower schemes and a lingering question over its legal status — so it was a decisive but not total or instant victory. It is worth being candid about the shape of that victory, because it is instructive. Cutting off the international financing did not, by itself, wipe the projects from the government's books; for a time the plans lingered in official strategy documents, formally alive though practically dead, and were only later removed. And beyond the two great dams the campaign defeated, the park remained dotted with plans for many smaller hydropower schemes, and its very legal status as a protected area was the subject of a drawn-out tussle. The lesson is that cutting off the money is often the decisive blow, but rarely the last one, and a campaign should be prepared to press on past the financiers' withdrawal to secure the formal cancellation and to guard against the threats that remain. The strategy leaned heavily on **international leverage** — the banks, the treaties, the global NGOs — which works when a project depends on international money and falls under international rules, but not every project does. And it took a **long campaign** — years of patient, expert work — not a quick protest. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of following the money and using the financiers' own

rules — and the lingering threats, the reliance on international leverage, and the long timelines that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a project and assume "the government has decided and the banks will fund it and nothing can be done," and never trace the financing, never invoke the safeguards or the treaties, never build the international case. They generate private worry without a public claim. The gap between a community that saves its park and one that loses it is rarely passion — Mavrovo's defenders had it in abundance. It is method: knowing how to follow the money, hold the financiers to their rules, invoke the treaties, and draw the world's attention.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the North Macedonian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a dam, a mine, a harmful development, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the decision, the financing, and the leverage)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION         (build the evidence — and the safeguard breach)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION       (build the national and international coalition)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES       (the safeguards, the treaties, and the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY         (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the safeguard complaint and the public argument at once; the coalition builds at home and abroad; a bank complaint or a treaty ruling is a headline and a headline builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a project stopped, its financing withdrawn, a park saved. The Mavrovo campaign did exactly this — it documented the harm and the safeguard breaches, built a national and international coalition, invoked the banks' rules and the treaties, and cut off the money.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. North Macedonia's — for a project that depends on international money — give communities a distinctive set:

- **Following the money to the financiers.** A project that **depends on international financing** can be stopped by cutting off that money, as Mavrovo's dams were. The power of this lever lies in a simple asymmetry: political will is cheap and local protest can be waited out, but the money for a great dam or mine is finite, specific, and often foreign, and a project deprived of it simply cannot be built no matter how badly the government wants it. Where the financing comes from an international development bank, it is doubly vulnerable, because it is both essential and bound by rules and watched by institutions that a national government cannot command; a campaign that identifies this dependence and targets it strikes at the one thing the project cannot do without, which is why following the money is often the most powerful move a Macedonian campaign of this kind can make.
- **The banks' own safeguard policies.** The development banks' **own environmental and social rules, and their complaint mechanisms**, can be used against them, as Eko-svest used them. This is the distinctive craft of such a campaign, and it rewards precision. The development banks publish detailed environmental and social policies — on biodiversity, on protected areas, on assessment and consultation — and they maintain formal accountability mechanisms through which an affected community can allege that a bank has broken those policies in a particular project. A well-documented complaint that proves such a breach does not merely embarrass a bank; it triggers the bank's own review, exposes it to reputational and institutional risk, and creates powerful internal pressure to withdraw. The Mavrovo campaigners built exactly such a complaint, and an independent review upheld it; a campaign that masters this mechanism turns the banks' own rules into the instrument of the project's defeat.
- **International treaties.** International instruments — like the **Bern Convention** on wildlife — can call for a project's suspension, as one did for Mavrovo.
- **The endangered species and the global hook.** A **critically endangered species or a globally valued place** — the Balkan lynx, an old-growth river — draws powerful international attention.
- **The courts and the process.** North Macedonia's **courts and environmental process** are a real lever, as a court found the Boškov Most licence unlawful.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver total, instant wins. Mavrovo's financing was cut, but the **formal**

cancellation lagged and **other threats lingered**. The strategy leaned on **international leverage** that not every project affords. And it took **years**. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools North Macedonia offers — following the money, the banks' own rules, the treaties, and the global hook — as the Mavrovo campaign used them to save a park and a lynx.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and — distinctively here — where the money comes from, because the financing is often the weakest link.

The Levels of Decision

A North Macedonian development or infrastructure project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the ministries. The **government and the relevant ministries** set policy, grant the licences, and champion the big projects, and can be moved by pressure, the courts, and the loss of financing, as the government's dam plans collapsed when the money vanished.

The international financiers. International development banks and investors — the World Bank, the EBRD, and others — often provide the money without which a big project cannot proceed, as they were to fund the Mavrovo dams. This is the distinctive pressure point. It is worth dwelling on why the financiers are so distinctively vulnerable, because it shapes the whole strategy. Unlike a national government, an international development bank answers to a board of many governments, publishes and is bound by its own environmental policies, maintains formal complaint mechanisms, and is acutely sensitive to its international reputation as a responsible lender; each of these is a handle a campaign can grip. A bank found to be funding a project that breaks its own rules and threatens a globally valued species faces a kind of accountability that a determined national government simply does not, which is why a project's dependence on such a bank, far from being a sign of its strength, is often the surest route to its defeat.

The developers and utilities. Domestic and foreign developers and utilities propose and build the projects.

The environmental process and the courts. The **environmental licensing and assessment process, and the courts**, are where a project is authorised — and where it can be found unlawful, as the Boškov Most licence was.

The community and the coalition. The **communities, the environmental organisations, the scientists, and the international allies** are the force that documents, campaigns, invokes the safeguards and treaties, and cuts off the money.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a government decision, through **environmental licensing** and the **arrangement of financing**, toward construction — with the **community, the courts, the financiers, and international bodies** able to challenge, withdraw, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive North Macedonian doors are the **financing** and the **banks' safeguard policies**, the **international treaties**, the **endangered-species and global hook**, and the **courts**. Find out exactly where your project stands, and, crucially, **whether it depends on international money, whether that money comes with safeguard rules, and whether an international treaty or a globally valued species is engaged**, because those are often where a project can be stopped.

Follow the Project, the Money, and the Rules

Behind a project stand a proponent — a developer, a utility, the government — and the officials who approve it. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly in North Macedonia — **where the financing comes from and what rules it carries, whether the environmental process and licence were lawful, what the project does to the land, the water, the wildlife, and whether an international treaty or an endangered species is engaged**. Two questions unlock most Macedonian fights of this kind: **Does it depend on international money, and does that money carry safeguard rules?** and **Is an international treaty or a globally valued species engaged?** The financing and the international dimension are, together, the heart of most such campaigns. The two work in tandem in a way particular to these fights: the dependence on international financing gives a campaign a concrete, severable lifeline to cut, while the international dimension — the banks' rules, the treaties, the globally valued species — gives it the leverage and the audiences to cut it. A campaign that grasps only that a project is foreign-funded, without mastering the rules and treaties

that bind that funding, may not know how to sever it; one that grasps the international rules without tracing the money may argue in the abstract; the Mavrovo campaign, like the strongest of its kind, joined the two — the traced dependence and the international rules — to cut the money off.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **international financiers' own accountability mechanisms**, which can find a bank in breach of its rules; **international treaties and their committees**, like the Bern Convention; the **courts**, which can find a licence unlawful; the **environmental process**; the **environmental organisations and scientists**, at home and abroad; the **free press**; and the **public**, at home and internationally. In North Macedonia, the **financing and the banks' safeguard rules, the international treaties, and the global hook**, backed by the **courts and the coalition**, are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a project that loses its financing, breaches the banks' rules, offends an international treaty, and threatens a globally valued species rarely proceeds — as the Mavrovo dams did not.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Macedonian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project **depends on international financing**, whether that money **carries safeguard rules** that can be invoked, whether an **international treaty or endangered species** is engaged, whether the **process or licence was unlawful**, and whether a **coalition at home and abroad** can be built. Where the project depends on international money and the international dimension is strong, North Macedonia's levers are powerful, as Mavrovo showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the win cut the financing yet the formal cancellation lagged, that other threats lingered, and that it took years.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Cutting off the financing	45-70%	1-5 years	low-moderate	The money withdrawn; the project stalled
The banks' safeguard complaint	40-65%	1-3 years	low	A bank found in breach; pressure to withdraw
International treaty / body	40-65%	1-3 years	low	A call to suspend; international weight
Endangered-species / global hook	40-65%	ongoing	low	Global attention and pressure
Court / process challenge	30-55%	1-3 years	low-moderate	A licence quashed; delay
National & international coalition	40-65%	ongoing	low-moderate	A capable, connected campaign
All steps (depends on int'l money, strong int'l dimension)	50-70%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Financing cut; project stopped
All steps (domestic money, weak int'l dimension)	25-50%	1-3 years	low-moderate	Delay; the record; partial

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and North Macedonia's real strengths are distinctive — **cutting off the financing**, the **banks' safeguard rules**, the **international treaties**, the **global hook**, and the **courts**. Its constraints are specific: the win may **cut the money but lag on formal cancellation**; it leans on **international leverage** not every project affords; and it takes **years**.

A note on cost: following the money, filing the safeguard complaints, invoking the treaties, and building the coalition cost mainly time, expertise, and international connection, and North Macedonia's environmental organisations and their global allies supply much of it. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the skill to follow the financing and wield the banks' own rules, and the reach to build an international coalition — exactly what the Mavrovo campaign brought.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (project stopped, financing withdrawn)

DEPENDS ON INT'L MONEY + SAFEGUARD RULES + A TREATY/SPECIES + A COALITION:

All steps combined:	50-70%
Cutting off the financing:	45-70%
Safeguard complaint + treaty:	40-65%
Court / process challenge:	30-55%
Single step:	5-70%

DOMESTIC MONEY / WEAK INT'L DIMENSION -- no foreign money, no treaty hook:

All steps combined:	25-50%
Courts + press:	the levers that remain
Delay / the record:	more achievable than a full stop
Single step:	5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in North Macedonia — for a project of this kind — are **cutting off the financing, the banks' safeguard rules, and the international treaties and hook**, backed by the courts and the coalition. Mavrovo shows the ceiling: a campaign followed the money, held the banks to their rules, and the dams lost their funding. But the honest floor is real too: the win cut the money yet the formal cancellation lagged, other threats lingered, and it took years. Many Macedonian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that following the money, the safeguards, the treaties, and the hook are powerful levers — decisive when a project depends on international money and the international dimension is strong, weaker when it does not, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and a partial gain. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a campaign against a project that depends on international financing, breaches the banks' rules, and threatens a globally valued species is in the strong band and can aim to cut off the money and stop it, as the Mavrovo campaign did; a campaign against a domestically funded project with no treaty hook is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at delay, a record, and a partial gain through the national courts and the press while it looks for whatever international dimension it can find. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and realistic where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Cutting off the financing and the banks' safeguard rules** — North Macedonia's most distinctive lever; following the money and holding the development banks to their own policies, as the Mavrovo campaign did.
2. **The international treaties and the global hook** — the wildlife treaty and the endangered species that drew international weight and attention to Mavrovo.
3. **The courts and the process** — the challenge that found the Boškov Most licence unlawful and constrained the project.
4. **The national and international coalition** — the alliance of local organisations, scientists, and global NGOs that carried the campaign.
5. **The scientists and the public** — the expert authority and the petitions that gave the campaign its weight at home and abroad.

What Macedonian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Following the money works** — cutting the international financing stopped the Mavrovo dams. **The banks' own rules are a weapon** — proving the breach of their safeguards forced their hand. **Treaties add weight** — the wildlife treaty's call to stop carried real force. **A global hook draws the world** — the Balkan lynx made it an international cause. **But the win cut the money, not always the plan** — the formal cancellation lagged and other threats lingered. The through-line: **follow the money; hold the financiers to their rules; invoke the treaties and the global hook; use the courts; and build the coalition — because in North Macedonia a project that depends on international money can be stopped by cutting it off.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and, distinctively here, where the money comes from, because the financing is often the leverage. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the dam whose international financing depends on safeguard rules it breaches, inside a park that shelters an endangered species" is a campaign — the kind that saved Mavrovo. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. Does it depend on international financing? This is the first Macedonian question of this kind. Does the project **depend on money from international development banks or investors** — the World Bank, the EBRD, others — without which it cannot proceed, as the Mavrovo dams depended on it? This should be the very first thing a campaign establishes, because it determines whether the distinctive Macedonian strategy is even available. A project financed entirely from domestic sources, or already fully funded, offers little purchase for the follow-the-money approach and must be fought more on the national ground of the courts, the process, and the public; a project that still depends on an uncommitted international loan is acutely vulnerable at that point of dependence. Tracing the financing early — which bank, on what terms, at what stage of commitment — tells a campaign at once whether it holds the most powerful lever of all, the ability to cut off the money before it flows.

2. Does that money carry safeguard rules? Does the financing come with the banks' **own environmental and social safeguard policies and complaint mechanisms**, which can be invoked against them, as Eko-svest invoked them? Give this question close and expert attention, because the strength of a safeguard complaint depends entirely on the precision with which it matches the breach to the rule. It is not enough to argue that a project is harmful; the complaint must show that the bank's own specific policy — on biodiversity, on protected areas, on the conduct of the assessment — required something the bank failed to do or ensure. The Mavrovo complaint succeeded because it demonstrated exactly such a failure, a proper assessment of the impact on the park's wildlife that the bank's own rules demanded and did not get; a campaign should study the financier's policies with the same rigour, to build a complaint the bank's own mechanism cannot dismiss.

3. Is an international treaty or an endangered species engaged? Does the project engage an **international treaty** — like the Bern Convention — or threaten a **globally valued place or endangered species**, like the Balkan lynx, that draws international weight? Weigh this carefully, because the global dimension is what elevates a local fight into one the international financiers and treaty bodies must heed. A project that threatens a critically endangered species found almost nowhere else, or a habitat of recognised international importance, or that breaches a treaty the country has signed, carries a resonance far beyond its borders and reaches audiences — the banks' boards, the treaty committees, the international press and public — that a purely local harm never touches. Establishing early whether such an international hook exists, and documenting it powerfully, tells a campaign how far its reach can extend and how much international pressure it can bring to bear on the money.

4. Was the process or licence unlawful? Was the **environmental process, assessment, or licence** flawed or unlawful under national law — the ground a court can act on, as a court acted on the Boškov Most licence.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which government body, developer, and financier are behind it, who profits; and which courts, the banks' mechanisms, the treaties, the organisations, scientists, press, and public — at home and abroad — can be engaged. This maps your levers and audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose a harmful dam or mine is proposed inside a protected area, dependent on a loan from an international development bank, threatening an endangered species.

Working the five questions: does it **depend on international financing**? Does that money **carry safeguard rules**? Is a **treaty or endangered species** engaged? Was the **licence unlawful**? And the deciders are the government, the developer, and the financier, with the banks' mechanisms, the treaties, the courts, and the coalition as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "they will build it" to a target list: document the harm and the safeguard breach; follow the money to the financier; invoke the safeguards, the treaty, and the global hook; challenge the licence; and build the coalition. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how Mavrovo was saved. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a seemingly settled project into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — trace the money, prove the safeguard breach, invoke the treaty and the global hook, challenge the licence, build the coalition — each tied to a specific lever that North Macedonia genuinely provides for a project of this kind. That reframing, from resignation to a plan built on the project's hidden vulnerability at the source of its money, is the difference the five questions make, and the first of them, whether the project depends on international financing, often decides how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, a bank's complaint mechanism, a treaty committee, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation. And because the distinctive Macedonian lever is holding

the financiers to their own rules, your evidence must prove not only the harm but the **breach of the banks' safeguards and the treaties**. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Financing, and the Rules

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **project plans, the licence, the environmental assessment** — and, distinctively, **trace the financing**: which bank or investor, on what terms, under which **safeguard policies**. Scrutinise the assessment and the process for flaws, and — crucially — scrutinise them against the **financier's own environmental and social rules and the international treaties**, because a breach of those rules is your strongest lever, as the breach of the banks' biodiversity policies was at Mavrovo. The gap between what the safeguards and treaties require and what was done is where many such Macedonian cases are grounded. The financing documents and the banks' safeguard policies therefore deserve as much scrutiny as the environmental assessment itself, because it is in the gap between them — what the bank's own biodiversity or protected-area policy requires, and what the assessment actually did — that the decisive complaint is built. A project may comply, more or less, with a lax national process while flagrantly breaching the far stricter rules its international financier is bound by, and a campaign that reads the bank's policies as closely as it reads the project's assessment frequently finds there, in the financier's own commitments, the precise breach on which the money can be cut off.

Layer 2: The Harm and the Global Hook

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **land, the water, the wildlife** at the centre — and, distinctively, the **globally valued place or endangered species**. Record the **harm** — to the river, the forest, the park, the wildlife — that the project would cause, as Mavrovo's defenders documented the threat to the park. And document the **global hook**: the endangered species, like the Balkan lynx, or the internationally valued habitat, whose loss draws the world's attention. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** and gather **scientific evidence**, which carries uniquely far here, as nearly two hundred scientists' voices carried at Mavrovo. This is the case that draws international weight.

Layer 3: The Breach, the Harm, and the Global Loss

Finally, document the case. Is there a **breach of the financiers' safeguards or an international treaty** — the assessment inadequate, the biodiversity ignored, the rules broken? Is the **harm** to land, water, and wildlife real and grave? And is a **globally valued place or endangered species** at stake, whose loss the world should not accept? Each is a separate ground — for the banks' mechanisms, the treaties, the courts, and the campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Macedonian fights of this kind, because here a project sold as development is revealed to breach the financiers' own rules, to threaten a globally valued place, and to depend on money that can be cut off — exactly the case that saved Mavrovo. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the safeguard and treaty breach, the grave harm, and the globally valued species at stake — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the safeguard breach is what the banks' mechanisms can act on and what cuts off the money, the harm is what the courts and the scientists respond to, and the global species is what draws the world's attention and the treaty bodies' concern. A campaign that documents only the harm may move the public without severing the funding; one that documents only the breach may win a technical finding without the weight of a global cause; the campaigns that prevail here, as Mavrovo's did, build all three and press them together.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Macedonian cases of this kind, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the financing, the safeguard breach, and the global loss.

The Project, the Financing, and the Paper Trail

- **The project plans and the licence** — how the project was authorised, and by which body.
- **The environmental assessment** — the study behind the licence, and its adequacy under national law and the financiers' rules.
- **The financing documents** — which bank or investor, on what terms, under which safeguard policies.
- **The safeguard policies and complaint mechanisms** — the banks' own environmental and social rules, and the routes to complain of a breach.
- **The treaty and protected-area status** — the international treaties engaged, and the place's protected status.

How to Get Them

The plans, licence, and assessment are matters of record, obtainable from the authorities and through access-to-information rules; the financing and safeguard documents from the banks themselves, whose policies and complaint mechanisms are public; the treaty and protected-area status from the international bodies and the environmental authorities. Lean on **allies**: North Macedonia's environmental organisations and their **international partners** — the finance-watchdog and conservation networks that know the banks' rules and the treaties intimately, as they knew them at Mavrovo. Move promptly: tracing the financing and lodging the safeguard complaint early — before the money is committed — is far more powerful than acting after, as the Mavrovo complaint was lodged years before the withdrawal. Timing is especially decisive in this kind of fight, because the leverage over the money is greatest before it is committed and diminishes once it flows and the works begin. A complaint lodged while a bank is still considering a loan, or before its board has finally approved it, strikes when the bank is most free to withdraw and most anxious to avoid funding a project that breaks its rules; a complaint lodged after the money is disbursed and the concrete is pouring faces a bank far more reluctant to reverse itself and a project with its own momentum. The Mavrovo campaigners moved early, lodging their complaint years before the eventual withdrawal; a campaign that traces the financing and complains at the earliest stage gives itself by far the greatest leverage over the money.

The Ground Evidence

- **The harm** — to the river, the forest, the park, the wildlife, documented.
- **The safeguard and treaty breach** — how the project breaks the banks' rules and the international treaties.
- **The global hook** — the endangered species or globally valued place, documented and made vivid.
- **The unlawful licence** — the flaws in the process and licence under national law.
- **Scientific evidence** — from national and international scientists, which carries far here.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the project, the licence, the financing, the safeguard breach, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom — the bank's mechanism, the treaty committee, the court, the press. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a lawyer, a scientist, a bank complaint officer, a treaty committee, a journalist, and the public all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the bank or the government pushes back. In a campaign that turns on proving a breach of the financiers' own rules, the community with the better-documented, more rigorous file is very often the one that forces the money to withdraw, as the Mavrovo campaign forced it.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE NATIONAL AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

Evidence and financing do not win on their own. An organised coalition does — and in North Macedonia, the Mavrovo campaign proved that a small national organisation, joined to powerful international allies, can cut off a project's money and stop it. A campaign's strength here is that coalition: rooted at home, connected abroad, and expert in the banks' rules and the treaties.

Phase 1: The Core and the Expertise

Start with a committed core — and, distinctively, with the **expertise** to follow the money and wield the banks' rules, as Eko-svest built it. Assign roles — documentation, the financing and safeguard case, the treaty case, legal, media, and international liaison. Agree on the goal — the project stopped, the financing withdrawn, the place saved — and on what the community will and will not accept. Draw on North Macedonia's environmental organisations and their hard-won knowledge of the development banks and the treaties. Building this expertise, or borrowing it, is worth a campaign's earliest effort, because the follow-the-money strategy is technical and unforgiving of error. Knowing which bank is bound by which policy, how and when to lodge a complaint with its accountability mechanism, what a treaty committee requires, and how the international machinery moves is specialised knowledge, and a campaign that lacks it can waste its best opportunities — missing the window to complain before the money is committed, or framing a breach too loosely for the mechanism to uphold. A community that either develops this expertise or, more often, partners early with the organisations that hold it gives itself the command of the tools on which this kind of victory depends.

Phase 2: The National and International Coalition

Then widen deliberately, at home and abroad. Bring in the **affected community and its neighbours**; the **national environmental organisations**, which bring the campaigning and the expertise; the **international finance-watchdog and conservation networks**, whose knowledge of the banks' rules and the treaties is decisive, as it was at Mavrovo; the **scientists**, national and international, whose voices carry uniquely far; sympathetic **lawyers**; and the **wider public**, at home and internationally. Reach the **press**, at home and abroad, because a project that threatens an endangered species and breaches a bank's rules is an international story. The Mavrovo campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — a small national group, global watchdogs, scientists, and international attention — which is precisely the spread a winning Macedonian campaign of this kind needs. The role of the international networks in that coalition deserves particular emphasis, because it is what makes the distinctive strategy possible. The finance-watchdog and conservation networks that specialise in the development banks and the environmental treaties carry knowledge that a local community cannot be expected to hold — how a particular bank's complaint mechanism works, what its biodiversity policy requires, how to bring a case to a treaty committee, how to reach the audiences in the bank's home countries — and they bring the international reach that pressures a distant financier. A campaign that connects early with these networks, as the Mavrovo campaigners did, gains access to a machinery of accountability that operates far beyond the national government's reach.

A worked coalition example. Facing a bank-funded dam, the community and national organisation form the base and the expertise; the international finance-watchdog and conservation networks bring the knowledge of the banks' rules; the scientists document the harm and the species; the lawyers challenge the licence; and the press, at home and abroad, carries the story. No single group could carry it; together they cover the money, the science, the law, and the world's attention — the model the Mavrovo campaign built. What is worth drawing from that model is how each element supplied what the others could not: the community and the national organisation brought the local standing and the sustained presence; the international finance-watchdog and conservation networks brought the intimate knowledge of the banks' rules and the treaties; the scientists brought the authority to establish the harm to a globally valued species; the lawyers brought the national court challenge; and the press, at home and abroad, brought the reputational pressure on the financiers. A community beginning such a fight should honestly assess which of these it holds and which it must recruit, because it is the completeness of the coalition — above all the joining of local roots to international expertise — that made the follow-the-money strategy work at Mavrovo.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and a Macedonian campaign of this kind can run for years, as Mavrovo's ran for the better part of a decade. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the financing traced, a safeguard complaint lodged, a treaty committee engaged, a court filing, a bank's breach confirmed, a wave of coverage. Keep the coalition connected and the campaign expert, and guard against the **discouragement and the slow pace** of a long, technical fight against distant banks and governments. Above all, keep following the money and pressing the rules, because a campaign that patiently holds the financiers to account, complaint by complaint and treaty by treaty, wears down even a determined project, as Mavrovo's patient campaign wore down two dams.

Phase 4: Following the Money and Pressing the Rules

Here is North Macedonia's distinctive strength, for a project that depends on international money. First, **follow the money**: identify the financiers and make cutting off their money the campaign's central aim, as Mavrovo's campaign did. Second, **press the rules**: lodge complaints to the banks' **own accountability mechanisms**, proving the breach of their **environmental and social safeguards**, as Eko-svest proved the breach of the biodiversity policies. Third, **invoke the treaties and the hook**: bring the **international treaty committees** and the **global attention** on the endangered species to bear, as the Bern Convention and the Balkan lynx were brought to bear. Keep it **rigorous, patient, and internationally connected**, because in this kind of fight it is the expert, well-documented pressure on the financiers and their rules, more than protest alone, that cuts off the money and stops the project — as it stopped the Mavrovo dams. It bears repeating that the emphasis here falls on the patient, expert pressure rather than on spectacle, because that is the distinctive character of this strategy and the source of its power. Street protest and public feeling have their place — they draw attention and lend the campaign a visible base — but what actually severs the money is the rigorously documented complaint that a bank cannot dismiss, the treaty submission a committee must consider, the court case that finds a licence unlawful. The Mavrovo campaign combined the visible and the technical, but it was the technical, patient work on the financiers' rules that ultimately cut the funding; a campaign should invest accordingly, resisting the temptation to mistake noise for the leverage that actually stops the money.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE SAFEGUARDS, THE

TREATIES, AND THE COURTS

North Macedonia's courts and environmental process, joined to the international financiers' safeguard mechanisms and the international treaties, are a real and distinctive legal toolkit. You do not need a single courtroom victory to win: a bank found in breach, a treaty committee's call to suspend, a licence quashed, a delay while the money is cut off, or a project abandoned when its financing vanishes can each be a real victory. Engage lawyers and the international networks early — but understand the tools.

The Financiers' Safeguard Mechanisms

The first and most distinctive lever is the **financiers' own safeguard mechanisms**. The development banks are bound by their **own environmental and social policies**, and they maintain **accountability or complaint mechanisms** through which an affected community can allege a breach — and a finding of breach is powerful pressure to withdraw. Lodge a complaint, prove the breach — the inadequate assessment, the ignored biodiversity — as Eko-svest lodged one and an independent review found the bank had broken its own rules. This is the lever that most directly cuts off the money.

The International Treaties

The second lever is the **international treaties**. Instruments like the **Bern Convention** on European wildlife have **committees that can call for a project's suspension** and direct their recommendations at the government and the financiers alike, as the Bern Convention's committee called for the Mavrovo construction to stop. It is worth understanding why a treaty committee's call carries such weight even without the force of a court order. A finding by a respected international wildlife treaty that a project threatens a protected species or habitat lends the campaign an authoritative, independent confirmation of the harm; it directs its recommendations not only at the government but at the financiers, giving the banks a further reason and cover to withdraw; and it places the project under an international scrutiny that a government eager for its European standing is reluctant to defy. The Bern Convention's intervention at Mavrovo, coming just before the first bank's withdrawal, was no coincidence; a campaign that brings a strong case to the right treaty committee adds a powerful, independent voice to its demand that the money be cut off. Invoke the relevant treaty, bring your evidence to its committee, and use its call to pressure both the government and the banks.

The Courts and the Process

The third lever is the **courts and the process**. North Macedonia's **courts** can find a **licence or an assessment unlawful** under national law, as a Macedonian court found the Boškov Most licence devoid of legal basis. The national court challenge, though it operates on different ground from the international levers, reinforces them powerfully, and is worth pursuing in parallel rather than as an afterthought. A ruling that a project's licence is unlawful under national law does more than delay the works: it hands the international financiers an independent, official confirmation that the project is legally defective in its own country, which makes continued funding far harder to justify and gives a wavering bank a clear reason to withdraw. At Mavrovo, the finding that a licence lacked any legal basis strengthened the case to the banks and the treaty body alike; a campaign should press the domestic legal challenge not only for its own sake but for the weight it adds to the demand that the money be cut off. Challenge a flawed licence, demand a proper assessment, and use the ruling and the delay to strengthen the case to the financiers and the treaties, because a project found unlawful at home is far harder for a bank to keep funding.

Where to Turn and With Whom

Safeguard complaints go through the **banks' own mechanisms**; treaty cases through the **treaty committees**; licence challenges through the **national courts**; all of it strengthened by the **international networks**. Get help early: North Macedonia's environmental organisations and their international finance-watchdog and conservation partners know the banks' rules, the treaties, and the courts, and their expertise was central to Mavrovo. Help engaged early — before the financing is committed — is worth far more than help sought after, and in North Macedonia the strongest strategy marries the **safeguard complaint, the treaty case, and the court challenge** to the central aim of **cutting off the international money**, so that a project loses the funding without which it cannot be built.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, a bank's

complaint mechanism, a treaty committee, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is the heart of a Macedonian campaign of this kind.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a dam would flood habitat critical to a critically endangered species inside a national park, on an assessment that ignored the biodiversity impact, funded by a bank whose own rules require that impact to be assessed. That one fact becomes:

- **A safeguard argument:** the bank breached its own biodiversity policy in funding this — the case before the bank's complaint mechanism.
- **A treaty argument:** the project violates an international wildlife treaty — the case before the treaty's committee.
- **A legal argument:** the licence and assessment breached national law — the case before the courts.
- **A global argument:** a species could be pushed to extinction — the case that draws the world's attention.
- **A public argument:** they would destroy our park and a rare wild creature for a dam that breaks the rules — the case that moves the nation.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in North Macedonia the arguments that most often decide things are the **safeguard** one, because it cuts off the money, and the **global-hook** one, because it draws the world's weight. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the assessment and a claim made to a bank can be proven against its own policy; rigour across audiences is, in this kind of fight, the very source of your power.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The banks' complaint mechanisms want the breach of the bank's own environmental and social policy, proven precisely against the policy and the assessment.

The treaty committees want the project framed against the treaty's obligations, with the evidence of the harm to the protected species or habitat.

The courts want the licence and assessment framed against national law, with the documents that prove the flaws.

Journalists need a vivid, specific story: a rare wild creature and a beloved park, threatened by a dam that breaks the rules and depends on international money.

The public and the world need the argument clear and stirring: a critically endangered species and a national park, to be destroyed for a rule-breaking dam.

The scientists respond to the honest technical case on the harm and the species.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in North Macedonia, where a project of this kind depends on international money and international reputation, coverage that draws national and international attention is among the most powerful levers of all. Coverage shames the financiers, pressures the government, and rallies the public at home and abroad. The Mavrovo campaign succeeded in part because it made an international story of a dam that would break the rules and doom a rare wild creature — a story the banks, sensitive to their reputations, could not ignore.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the global hook and the rule-breaking. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a dam that would doom a critically endangered wild cat inside a national park, funded by banks breaking their own environmental rules" is — the kind of story that saved Mavrovo. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the endangered species, the safeguard breach, the harm — and offer a human and expert voice: a scientist, a resident, a conservationist. In North Macedonia, and to the world, the story of a rare creature and a beloved park threatened by a rule-breaking, bank-funded dam is one that draws real attention.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first. Then the **national outlets** — because national opinion pressures the government. Then, distinctively, the **international ring** — the international press, the conservation and finance-watchdog networks, and the audiences in the banks' own home countries — because the financiers are **sensitive to their international reputations**, and international attention is what most pressures them to withdraw, as it pressured the banks at Mavrovo. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international ring is distinctively decisive** here, because it reaches the financiers where they are most vulnerable.

Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Macedonian campaign of this kind runs for years. Plan a sequence — the threat, the safeguard breach, the treaty call, the court ruling, the bank's withdrawal — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation, the world, and the banks. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and rigorous; the banks and the government will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, safeguard-and-species-centred campaign is what moves the financiers. Verified, specific, species-and-rule-centred, and internationally aimed — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped cut off the Mavrovo dams' money.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, complain, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the authorities, the financiers, the treaty committees, the courts, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the financing, the safeguard breach, and the harm.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant authority / the financier **Subject:** Request for information on [project]

We, [community/organisation], request the **project plans, the licence, the environmental assessment, and the financing and safeguard documents** for [project]. This project affects a protected area, a species, and the public interest, and the public has a right to know. Please provide the documents.

8B. Complaint to the Financier's Accountability Mechanism

To: the accountability / complaint mechanism of [the bank] **Subject:** Complaint regarding [project] — breach of the bank's environmental and social policies

We, [community/organisation], an affected community, submit that [the bank]'s financing of [project] **breaches its own environmental and social safeguard policies**: the assessment **ignored the impact on [the endangered species / the protected area]**, contrary to the bank's biodiversity policy. We request that the mechanism **review the breach** and that the bank **withdraw its financing**, and we attach the evidence.

8C. Submission to the Treaty Committee

To: the committee of [the international treaty, e.g. the Bern Convention] **Subject:** [Project] threatens [the protected species / habitat] contrary to [the treaty]

We, [community/organisation], bring to the committee that [project] threatens [the protected species / habitat] in breach of [the treaty]. We request that the committee **call for the suspension of the project** pending a full assessment, and direct its recommendation to the government and the financiers. We attach the evidence.

8D. Court Challenge (with a Lawyer)

To: the court (via counsel) **Subject:** Challenge to the licence for [project]

On behalf of [community/organisation], we challenge the licence for [project] as **unlawful**: the assessment **ignored the harm** and the licence was granted **contrary to national environmental law**. We seek its **annulment** and the halting of

works, and attach the record demonstrating the flaws.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / International Network

To: an environmental organisation / finance-watchdog network / lawyer **Subject:** [Project] — the financing, the safeguards, and the challenge

We are opposing [project]. We attach the plans, the assessment, the financing details, and our evidence of harm and safeguard breach, and seek advice on **the bank complaint, the treaty case, and the court challenge**. Please advise on the strongest routes and the deadlines.

8F. Appeal to Scientists

To: a scientist / scientific network **Subject:** Help us save [the species / the park] at [place]

We write regarding [project], which would harm [the endangered species / the park] at [place]. As nearly two hundred scientists once spoke for Mavrovo and its lynx, we ask for your **expertise, your evidence, and your voice** — including, if you are willing, an open letter — to establish the harm and draw the world's attention. We attach our case.

8G. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the species / the park / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a story of international interest, with a clear hook: [documents] show [finding — e.g. "a dam funded by international banks breaking their own rules would doom a critically endangered species in a national park"]. It echoes Mavrovo. I can share the file and connect you with a scientist and a conservationist. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/organisation] opposes [project]

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would **destroy [the park / the habitat]** and threaten [the endangered species], funded by international money in **breach of the financiers' own rules** and [the treaty]. As the defenders of Mavrovo cut off the money and saved the lynx, we will follow the money, hold the banks to their rules, invoke the treaties, and draw the world's attention until this project is stopped. We will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a request, a complaint, or a submission is itself evidence, and exactly what the banks, the treaty committees, the courts, and the world will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the financing, the safeguard breach, and the harm; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, the national and international networks, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the ruling, becomes part of your record, and in North Macedonia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the safeguard complaint, the treaty case, the court challenge, and the international attention that cut off the money.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a years-long international campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Follow the money.** Find out whether the project depends on international financing, and from which bank (Step 1, 8A).
- 2. Find the safeguard breach.** Get the assessment and check it against the bank's own environmental rules (Step 2).
- 3. Lodge the bank complaint.** With help, complain to the financier's accountability mechanism (8B, 8E).
- 4. Reach the international networks.** Connect with finance-watchdog and conservation networks who know the banks and treaties (8E).

5. Invoke the treaty and the scientists. Bring in the treaty committee and the scientists' voices (8C, 8F).

6. Challenge the licence. With a lawyer, challenge a flawed licence in the courts (8D).

7. Draw the world's attention. Take the endangered species and the rule-breaking to the international press (Step 5, 8G).

Do only the first three and you will have followed the money, found the breach, and lodged the complaint — the foundation of a Macedonian defence of this kind. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: follow the money, find the breach, complain to the bank.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

North Macedonia's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. **Powerful energy and development interests**, and a government that champions big projects as growth, carry weight, and a project is presented as the nation's progress. The **environmental institutions can be under-resourced or pressured** to license a favoured project — as a court found a licence unlawful precisely because the process had been bent. **International financing can arrive despite the rules** — as a bank once approved a loan before the assessment was even finished. And the **formal decisions can lag** behind the campaign's wins, leaving a project half-alive. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the national process will protect the place, or that a bank will follow its own rules unprompted, will be disappointed — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to follow the money and force the rules.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even against this tilt, real levers remain — and the distinctive ones are strong.

Following the money still works. A project that depends on international financing can be stopped by cutting it off, as Mavrovo's dams were.

The banks' own rules still bind. A bank can be forced to confront its breach of its own safeguards, and to withdraw.

The treaties still carry weight. An international wildlife treaty's call to suspend a project carries real force.

The global hook still draws the world. A critically endangered species draws an international attention no government relishes.

The courts still constrain. A Macedonian court can find a licence unlawful, as one found the Boškov Most licence.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for North Macedonia is realistic but, for the right project, genuinely hopeful: the national process tilts toward development and can be bent, but for a project that depends on international money and engages the treaties and a global species, following the money and forcing the rules gives a campaign powerful, distinctive levers. So diagnose your fight honestly: **follow the money**; find the **safeguard and treaty breach**; document the **harm and the global hook**; **challenge the licence**; and build the **national and international coalition** — while understanding that the win may cut the money before the formal cancellation, that other threats may linger, and that the fight takes years. Do not assume the process or the banks will protect the place unprompted; Mavrovo was saved because a campaign followed the money and would not let the banks ignore their own rules.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

North Macedonia has real and documented concerns about corruption and the capture of decisions by powerful interests, so this section matters. When a project is driven not by the public interest but by the connected, or by an energy or

construction interest's weight over the institutions, your strategy includes exposing that.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **licence granted against the evidence and the law** — as a court found at Mavrovo; an **assessment shaded or rushed** to favour a chosen project — as a bank once lent before the assessment was done; **close ties** between the developers, the officials, and the connected; **public money or public assets** steered to a favoured project; and **benefits to the connected** while the public and the environment bear the harm. Trace the decision and the interests: who pushed the project, who profits, whether the process and the licence were bent to suit them. In North Macedonia, a harmful project pushed through against the law and the evidence is worth examining for the influence behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the government, the institutions, and the licensing bodies** can be captured or pressured by powerful interests. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **international financiers' accountability mechanisms** and the **treaty committees**, beyond the reach of national capture; the **courts**, which can find a licence unlawful; the **international networks and scientists**; the **free press**; and the **public**, at home and abroad. Distinctively, the international dimension is what most escapes national capture; your task is to document the capture, prove the breach of the international rules, and bring it to the financiers, the treaties, the courts, and the world.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured licence cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the licence was granted against the law, the assessment rushed, who profits — and take it to the forces that can act: the **financiers' mechanisms and the treaty committees**, beyond national capture; the **courts**, to quash the unlawful licence; the **international networks and press**, to expose it; and the **public**. Pair the exposure with the safeguard breach and the global hook, so the impropriety and the harm arrive together. In North Macedonia, exposing how a rule-breaking, bank-funded project was pushed through a captured process against the law, and bringing that to the international financiers and the world, is often the way to cut off its money and stop it — as the exposure of the breaches cut off the Mavrovo dams.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in North Macedonia, for a project of this kind, turns on the financing, the safeguards, and the international dimension.

Early (Months 0-8): The Money, the Breach, and the Coalition

Pin down the project and the deciding bodies (Step 1); **follow the money** to the financiers, document the **harm and the global hook**, and identify the **safeguard and treaty breach** (Step 2). Build the **national and international coalition** (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); **lodge the bank complaint** (8B); reach the **international networks and scientists** early (8E, 8F); and begin to **draw attention** (Step 5). This phase lays the foundation, and in North Macedonia the traced financing and the documented breach established here are what win.

Middle (Months 6-48+): Complain, Challenge, and Pressure

Sustain the coalition and press the campaign (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Pursue the **bank complaint, the treaty case, and the court challenge** (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, at home and abroad, aimed at the financiers' reputations (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — lodging the bank complaint before the money is committed — because that chance is most powerful early.

Later (Months 12-many): The Withdrawal, and Vigilance

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **financing withdrawn and the project stopped** — and then stay vigilant, because, as Mavrovo showed, the formal cancellation may lag, other threats may linger, and a project starved of one financier may seek another. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a project stopped when its money is cut off. Sometimes it is a bank's withdrawal that stalls the project while the formal decision and the remaining threats are still being fought. Both

are victories worth the fight.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-8 Follow the money + document the harm/hook | Find the safeguard breach | Build the coalition | Lodge the bank complaint
MONTHS 6-48+ Bank complaint + treaty case + court challenge | Draw international attention | Media
MONTHS 12-many Financing withdrawn / project stopped | Stay vigilant, for the formal cancellation may lag

FINAL ASSESSMENT

North Macedonia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Following the money** to the international financiers can stop a project that depends on that money, as it stopped the Mavrovo dams. The banks' **own safeguard policies and complaint mechanisms** can be used against them, forcing a withdrawal. **International treaties** can call for a project's suspension and carry real weight. A **critically endangered species or a globally valued place** draws an international attention that governments and banks cannot ignore. And the **courts** can find a licence unlawful. These are the tools that let a small national organisation and its allies cut off the money and save a national park and a nearly-extinct wild cat. They are, notably, tools that reward rigour, patience, and international connection rather than numbers or force, which is why a small organisation in the capital, armed with the banks' own rules and a global alliance, could prevail over its own government's determination to build; and why, used with the same rigour, they remain available to communities across North Macedonia wherever a destructive project depends on international money and threatens a valued place.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The Mavrovo win **cut off the financing**, but the formal cancellation lagged and the park faced other, lingering threats — a decisive but not total or instant victory. The strategy leaned on **international leverage** — the banks, the treaties, the global networks — that works for a project dependent on international money and engaging international rules, but not for every project. And it took **years** of patient, technical work. No guide should pretend these away; in North Macedonia, the art is to follow the money, force the rules, invoke the treaties and the hook, and keep watch, because a starved project may seek new money and the formal decision may lag.

So the realistic promise is this: **follow the money; find the safeguard and treaty breach; document the harm and the global hook; challenge the licence; and build the national and international coalition — running all of it together.** Do that, and where the project depends on international money and the international dimension is strong, you can cut off the financing and stop it, as Mavrovo's dams were stopped; where it does not, you can still win delay, a record, and a partial gain. Do it as the Mavrovo campaign did — a small national organisation and its global allies who followed the money, held the banks to their own rules, and would not let a rule-breaking dam doom a park and a lynx.

A last word on following the money. North Macedonia's lesson is that a project which seems unstoppable at home may be vulnerable far away, at the source of its money — that a small campaign, armed with rigour and international connection, can hold a distant bank to its own rules and cut off the funding without which the bulldozers cannot start — but that the win may cut the money before the plan, that other threats may linger, and that the fight is long and technical. The powerful count on your believing that the money is beyond your reach and the decision already made. Their advantage is the distance, the complexity, and the slow pace of the international machinery. Yours is the banks' own rules, the treaties, the global attention on a rare creature, the courts, and the proven fact that Mavrovo's defenders cut off the money and saved the park. Play to that. Keep the rigorous record and the proof of the breach, keep the coalition connected at home and abroad, follow the money and press the rules, and treat every complaint lodged, every breach confirmed, every treaty call, and every euro of financing withdrawn as a stone in a wall that even a determined government cannot easily climb.

The tools are here, and North Macedonia itself proved them: a small organisation and its international allies who followed the money to two great banks, held them to their own environmental rules, invoked a wildlife treaty and rallied the world around a nearly-extinct wild cat, and cut off the financing until two dams inside a national park could not be built. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the rigour of the case, the reach of the coalition, the pressure on the financiers and their rules, and the weight of the treaties and the global hook — and those a determined community can summon. Begin today, begin by following the money and finding the breach and building the coalition, and build from there. Communities before you have cut off the money and saved a wild place — a dam stopped, a park saved, a species spared. What the Mavrovo campaign won can be won again. So can yours. A small organisation that traced the money to two great banks, held them to the environmental rules they had written for themselves, summoned a wildlife treaty and the world's concern for a vanishing wild cat, and cut off the financing until two dams could not be built, has shown what rigour and international reach can achieve against even a determined government; following the money, forcing the safeguards, invoking the treaties and the global hook, and building the coalition are the method, and the proof that a project can be

stopped at the source of its money is now yours to take up and use.